Hermann Usener — Götternamen (1896)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

This edition is dedicated to Hermann Usener (1834–1905), founder of the Bonn school of religious history. He taught Friedrich Nietzsche briefly, and he also taught Hermann Diels, Albrecht Dieterich, and Richard Reitzenstein, while Aby Warburg belongs to the same line by intellectual descent, so his influence scattered far beyond his own pages through the students who carried his questions onward. In *Götternamen* he traced the names of gods to language and to momentary experience, and his momentary god entered English-language scholarship even though the book itself was always read in German. The dedication honours the teacher as well as the thinker.

The author's own terms

Augenblicksgott, the “momentary god,” is Usener's term for a god understood as arising from a single vivid experience — from what a person feels and names in a particular moment.

The story

Hermann Usener (1834–1905) was the founder of the Bonn school of religious history. That phrase means, in plain words, that a group of scholars working around him at Bonn changed how the history of religion was studied. He taught,

briefly, Friedrich Nietzsche, and he also taught Hermann Diels, Albrecht Dieterich, and Richard Reitzenstein. Aby Warburg belongs to the same line by intellectual descent.

His masterwork is *Götternamen: Versuch einer Lehre von der religiösen Begriffsbildung*, published at Bonn in 1896. Its full title can be rendered as "The Names of the Gods: Toward a Theory of Religious Concept-Formation." The book asks how the names of gods arise. Usener traced those names to language and to momentary experience — to what a person feels and names in a particular moment. From that argument came the "momentary god," the *Augenblicksgott*, a god understood as arising from a single vivid experience.

The idea travelled. The concept of the momentary god entered English-language scholarship, and English-language writers have discussed Usener's book extensively. The book itself, however, was always read in German. An English reader who wanted Usener's full argument, in his own order and at his own length, had no English book to open.

That is the quiet loss at the centre of this dossier. Nothing here was destroyed. A complete, printed German work survives, by an author who died in 1905, and the work is in the public domain. What is missing is access in English to the whole argument that made one of its ideas famous.

The work and what survives

The work survives as one volume of about 391–408 pages. The page range is given here as it appears in the record; the two counts are not reduced to a single figure in this research. A third unchanged edition was published at Frankfurt in 1948, still in German. Listings for public-domain reprints confirm United States public-domain status. The author died in 1905, and the original imprint is dated 1896.

The scan identifiers are to be pinned when a translation is prepared. That step remains open, and it is recorded here as open rather than as settled.

The book is a single volume, which makes it, in practical terms, one of the most readily completable complete masterworks in this survey. It is not a fragment and it is not a multi-volume project. Its difficulty lies elsewhere: it contains heavy material in Greek and Latin divine epithets — the descriptive titles and bynames given to gods — and that material has to be handled accurately.

Its English fortunes

No English translation found after research.

That bounded wording matters. English-language scholarship discusses the book extensively, but it does so always from the German. The idea of the momentary god crossed into English. The complete book did not.

What completing it would take

Completing it would take a translation of the single German volume. Because of the Greek and Latin divine-epithet material, the work would need a checking stage by one classicist — a scholar of Greek and Latin — before it could be presented as reliable.

It also forms a natural pair with the dossier on Albrecht Dieterich. Dieterich was Usener's student and his son-in-law, and reading teacher and student together would show how one scholar's question about the names of gods became, in the next generation, a study of folk religion and the earth.

Sources

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hermann_Usener (life, school, the Götternamen and the momentary-god concept)
- https://www.thriftbooks.com/w/gtternamen/16714435/ (edition data; public-domain reprint record)
- https://hal.science/hal-04891703v1/document (scholarly treatment of Usener's religious concept-formation)